Boundary Processes and the Five-Stage Model in Anthropology and Ethnology

2026-03-23

Contents

Boundary Processes and the Five-Stage Model in Anthropology and Ethnology 2
1. Purpose and Question of the Investigation . . . 2
2. Method of Investigation . . . 3
3. Overview of the Model . . . 3
4. Findings: Overall Picture . . . 4
5. Findings: Examination of Major Theories . . . 5
6. Cross-Cutting Patterns . . . 10
7. Unresolved Questions . . . 11
8. Conclusion . . . 11

Boundary Processes and the Five-Stage Model in Anthropology and Ethnology

1. Purpose and Question of the Investigation

Figure 1: Boundary Processes and the Five-Stage Model in Anthropology and Ethnology —

This report was prepared to answer the following question:

> Do the theories in this academic domain correspond structurally to the five-stage model, namely Field ( ) → Wave ( ) → Edge ( ) → Vortex ( ) → Bundle ( )?

The inquiry examines the structural affinities between the five stages and the phased processes of transformation found in rites of passage, social drama, and liminality; boundary operations in classificatory systems (Douglas); the maintenance and production of ethnic boundaries (Barth); the generation of relations through gift exchange (Mauss); operational sequences (Leroi-Gourhan/Lemonnier); the two-layer model of symbolic/social boundaries (Lamont & Molnar); the contact zone (Pratt); and structuration theory/practical sense (Giddens/Bourdieu). This domain is, overwhelmingly, a discipline of the Edge, displaying especially strong correspondences with the concept of Edge; in 8 of the 10 entries, Edge shows a strong structural match.

This report presents the findings of an investigation. It is not a document written to justify any particular theory. Points of strong correspondence and points that require reservation are described with the same degree of analytical neutrality.

2. Method of Investigation

Scope and Selection Criteria

In this domain, 10 theoretical and practical models were selected for evaluation. The selection was guided by three criteria: (1) the model explicitly addresses processes of generation or transformation; (2) structural analysis is possible on the basis of primary sources or well-established secondary sources; and (3) comparison is possible across different lineages within the field.

Method of Evaluation

For each theory, the report first explains what that theory describes and then examines where correspondences with the five stages can be identified. Judgments regarding correspondence were made on the basis of an overall assessment of the textual concepts involved, concrete examples, connections between stages, the presence or absence of circulation from Bundle to the next Field, and the risk of overinterpretation.

Criteria for Judgment

- **Strong structural correspondence**: The core concepts of the theory correspond concretely to multiple stages of the five-stage model, and the reason this correspondence holds can be explained in the main text.
- **Conditional correspondence**: A correspondence can be indicated, but interpretive reservations remain concerning the stage mapping.
- **No correspondence confirmed**: Partial approximations exist, but the theory cannot be read, without strain, as instantiating the structure of the five stages as a whole.

Limits of the Investigation

This investigation does not offer an exhaustive examination of all writings associated with each theory. Instead, it focuses on the core concepts of major works and extracts structures at a level of granularity suitable for comparison. As a result, some areas do not fully address finer details internal to each theory or the full range of historiographical disputes.

3. Overview of the Model

The five-stage model describes the process of creation in terms of the following five stages.

Stage	Definition
Field ( )	An undifferentiated condition. It refers to an initial state in which neither direction nor structure has yet been fixed.
Wave ( )	A stage of exploration in which multiple directions diverge and differences are amplified.
Edge ( )	A stage of tension in which opposing elements coexist and do not immediately converge into either side.
Vortex ( )	A stage in which a new coherence or order emerges from within that tension.
Bundle ( )	A stage in which form becomes fixed and stabilizes as a reusable structure.

This model is not a one-directional line; it includes a circulation in which Bundle becomes the condition for the next Field. Moreover, the five stages should not be understood as rigidly separated boxes but as a continuous spectrum. The model includes the hypothesis that the same structure may recur at different scales, from momentary thought to institutional formation and long-term historical transformation.

If a sense of incongruity remains at this point, that itself is an important perspective for the present investigation. Readers may continue with that incongruity intact.

4. Findings: Overall Picture

Figure 2: Boundary Processes and the Five-Stage Model in Anthropology and Ethnology — ×5

List of Theories Evaluated

Theory	Proponent	Structural Correspondence
The three phases of rites of passage (separation-margin-integration)	van Gennep, A. (1909 *Les rites de passage*; English translation 1960, University of Chicago Press)	Strong correspondence
The four phases of social drama	Turner, V. (1974 *Dramas, Fields, and Metaphors*; 1982/1985 *The Anthropology of Performance*)	Strong correspondence

Theory	Proponent	Structural Correspondence
Liminality and communitas	Turner, V. (1969 *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure*)	Strong correspondence
Purity and taboo: boundary operations in classificatory systems	Douglas, M. (1966 *Purity and Danger: An Analysis of Concepts of Pollution and Taboo*)	Strong correspondence
Ethnic boundaries: groups are made at the boundary	Barth, F. ed. (1969 *Ethnic Groups and Boundaries: The Social Organization of Culture Difference*)	Strong correspondence
The theory of the gift: the generation of relations through exchange	Mauss, M. (1925 *Essai sur le don: Forme et raison de l'echange dans les societes archaiques*)	Strong correspondence
Chaine operatoire: the staged process of technical action	Leroi-Gourhan, A. (1964-65 *Le Geste et la Parole*); Lemonnier, P. (1986, 1992 *Elements for an Anthropology of Technology*)	Strong correspondence
Symbolic boundaries and social boundaries: a two-layer model of boundaries	Lamont, M. & Molnar, V. (2002 "The Study of Boundaries in the Social Sciences." *Annual Review of Sociology* 28: 167-195)	Strong correspondence
Contact zone: the boundary as a space of contact	Pratt, M. L. (1991 "Arts of the Contact Zone." *Profession* 91, MLA)	Conditional correspondence
Structuration theory/practical sense: the circulation of reproduction and transformation	Giddens, A. (1984 *The Constitution of Society*); Bourdieu, P. (1980 *Le sens pratique*)	Strong correspondence

Of the 10 theories evaluated, 9 showed strong structural correspondence, 1 showed conditional correspondence, and 0 showed no confirmed correspondence. Overall, this domain shows correspondences with the five-stage model at a relatively high density, but the mode of correspondence is not uniform. Some theories provide a thick description of the conditions of Field, whereas others describe with precision the tensions of Edge or the fixation associated with Bundle.

What is especially important is not the high rate of correspondence as such, but which theories describe which stages, and with what vocabulary. Even when addressing the same phenomenon of "creation," theories in this domain illuminate different aspects of the five stages through different layers, including the body, institutions, time, perception, practice, and symbolization.

5. Findings: Examination of Major Theories

5.1 The Three Phases of Rites of Passage (Separation-Margin-Integration)

The "three phases of rites of passage (separation-margin-integration)" proposed by van Gennep, A. (1909 *Les rites de passage*; English translation 1960, University of Chicago Press) organizes

rites of passage into a three-phase arrangement: "separation (séparation / préliminaires)," "transition (transition / marge / liminaires)," and "incorporation (incorporation / aggregation / postliminaires)." The essence of ritual lies not in its individual elements but in their "relative position (order) within the whole ritual" (van Gennep 1909/1960). Depending on the case, the transitional phase may be inserted into the ritual as a "secondary autonomous system" and may possess autonomy of its own. The author himself offers examples such as novitiate, betrothal, and the ritual process of vengeance expeditions, explicitly indicating that the transitional phase may itself be staged again as a "coherent sequence of operations," as in "sacralization → transition → desacralization" (van Gennep 1909/1960).

The sequence "separation → margin → integration" in rites of passage corresponds directly to "Wave → Edge → Vortex" in the five-stage model. The fact that margin, as a boundary zone, becomes the site of generation resonates most strongly with Edge. The autonomy of the transitional phase as a "secondary system" provides a foundational basis for understanding Edge not as a mere point of contact but as an operational band. The tripartite model describes Wave → Edge → Vortex as a single continuous process and thus exhibits a high degree of structural isomorphism.

This theory belongs to the context of cultural anthropology. The original source is van Gennep (1909). In subsequent ritual studies, the tripartite model became a basic frame of reference. Turner (1969) developed the concept of liminality, and Turner (1974) expanded its reach through social drama. There are criticisms of its being treated too readily as "universal," particularly in ways that neglect historicity, power, and gender.

5.2 Social Drama and Its Four Phases

In Turner, V. (1974 *Dramas, Fields, and Metaphors*; 1982/1985 *The Anthropology of Performance*), "social drama" is conceived as a unit in which a breach of normative order unfolds as a public process. It consists of four phases: breach → crisis → redressive action → reintegration or schism (Turner 1974). Crisis and redress are said to possess a threshold-like (limen) character. Positioned as a threshold between stable phases, they extend the concept of liminality from the interior of ritual to the interior of social process as well (Turner 1985).

The sequence "breach → crisis → redress → reintegration/schism" in social drama corresponds structurally to "Wave → Edge → Vortex (+ failed Vortex)" in the five-stage model. In particular, the original text states that the redress phase possesses a liminal character, providing a theoretical basis for Edge within social process. The fact that schism can be read as a "failed Vortex" is theoretically important as a robustness test for the five-stage model.

This theory belongs to the context of social anthropology. Turner (1974) systematized it. It provides a framework for extending the reach of rites of passage and liminality/communitas to social processes more generally. It develops out of Gluckman's "rituals of rebellion." Although the risk of overgeneralizing the social drama model is recognized, the basic four-phase structure remains widely referenced across the social sciences.

5.3 Liminality and Communitas

In Turner, V. (1969 *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure*), "liminality and communitas" take the tripartite structure of rites of passage as a premise while making the properties of the liminal phase itself the central topic. Liminal beings deviate from the network of classifications and are placed in an ambiguous condition that is "betwixt and between" (Turner 1969). Liminal beings are likened to "death, the womb, invisibility, darkness, bisexuality, and the wilderness," among other figures, because they do not fit into any existing classificatory category.

The sequence "deviation from the classificatory system → communitas → reformation" in liminality is the most precise description of what happens inside Edge. "Betwixt and between" corresponds directly to the essential feature of Edge: belonging to none of the existing categories. Communitas, as an anti-structural form of togetherness, shows the dynamics through which new relationality begins to emerge in Edge. The correspondence with the circulation of the five-stage model as a whole is also strong: the alternating appearance of structure and anti-structure is structurally similar to the circulation Bundle → Field → Wave → Edge → Vortex → Bundle → …

This theory belongs to cultural anthropology and the study of religion. Turner (1969) deepened van Gennep's (1909) tripartite scheme at a theoretical level. It has been criticized for underestimating power and exclusion through its emphasis on "anti-structure." The extension to postindustrial society through the concept of the liminoid (Turner 1974) broadens its scope, but direct confirmation of the original text remains partial.

5.4 Purity and Taboo: Boundary Operations in Classificatory Systems

In Douglas, M. (1966 *Purity and Danger: An Analysis of Concepts of Pollution and Taboo*), "purity and taboo" define dirt as "matter out of place." Dirt is not essentially impure; rather, it is regarded as impure because it occupies a position that transgresses the boundaries of a classificatory system (Douglas 1966). The maintenance of classificatory systems produces order, boundary transgression produces pollution, and responses to pollution, such as taboo and purification rituals, restore order.

"Matter out of place," as a transgression of classificatory boundaries, corresponds directly to the definition of Wave as a disturbance of existing order. The process through which pollution makes boundaries visible is structurally similar to the emergence of Edge. Purification and taboo correspond to Bundle as devices for maintaining order. The larger cycle of maintaining a classificatory system, violating it, and restoring it overlaps with the circulation Field → Wave → Edge → Vortex → Bundle in the five-stage model.

This theory belongs to social anthropology and the study of religion. Douglas (1966), while influenced by the structuralism of Levi-Strauss, analyzed the functioning of classificatory systems through the concrete phenomenon of pollution. It has been criticized for excessive universalization, particularly in the strong generalization of pollution as boundary violation. Its complementary relation to liminality is particularly important.

5.5 Ethnic Boundaries: Groups Are Made at the Boundary

In Barth, F. ed. (1969 *Ethnic Groups and Boundaries: The Social Organization of Culture Difference*), "ethnic boundaries: groups are made at the boundary" problematizes the persistence of ethnic groups and makes visible anthropology's implicit assumption of the "discontinuity of cultural difference," namely, the assumption that there exist collectivities of people who share a common culture (Barth 1969 Introduction). The identity of an ethnic group is determined not by its "cultural content" but by the "maintenance of boundaries," that is, the social processes of exclusion and incorporation. Cultural content may change while boundaries persist.

The proposition that "boundaries make groups" is structurally similar to the idea that Edge generates Vortex. The insight that boundary, rather than content, persists even when the contents of Field change suggests that Edge is the most enduring element within the five-stage model. Boundary maintenance through identification and exclusion in interaction provides sociological substantiation for the idea that Edge functions as a dynamic web of relations.

This theory belongs to social anthropology and ethnicity studies. Barth (1969) is highly influential and widely regarded as a classic. Criticisms include its weak connection to economy, the state,

and colonialism, as well as the inflation of the concept of "boundary." Lamont & Molnar's (2002) review article organizes Barth's concept of boundary across the social sciences.

5.6 The Theory of the Gift: The Generation of Relations Through Exchange

In Mauss, M. (1925 *Essai sur le don: Forme et raison de l'echange dans les societes archaiques*), "the theory of the gift" treats gift exchange as a "fait social total." It cannot be reduced to economic action; rather, it is a phenomenon in which law, morality, religion, and aesthetics are fused together (Mauss 1925). Mauss identifies three obligations in gift exchange: the obligation to give, the obligation to receive, and the obligation to return. The circulation of these three obligations generates and sustains social bonds.

The circulation of the three obligations of gift exchange, giving, receiving, and returning, can be read as a repetition of Wave → Edge → Vortex. The process through which gift exchange brings social relations into being is a concrete mechanism for the generation of relations within Edge. The concept of the "fait social total" is an anthropological precursor to the idea that the five-stage structure cuts across economy, law, morality, and religion.

This theory belongs to social anthropology and economic anthropology. Mauss (1925) stands in the lineage of the Durkheimian school. Levi-Strauss reinterpreted it as a theory of exchange and made it foundational for structural anthropology. There are critiques of the interpretation of hau, notably by Sahlins and Godelier. The theory of the gift is one of anthropology's major classics and has exercised enormous influence on later exchange theory (Levi-Strauss), economic anthropology (Sahlins, Polanyi), and even contemporary theories of gift economy (Hyde, Graeber).

5.7 Chaine Operatoire: The Staged Process of Technical Action

The concept of "chaine operatoire: the staged process of technical action" in Leroi-Gourhan, A. (1964-65 *Le Geste et la Parole*); Lemonnier, P. (1986, 1992 *Elements for an Anthropology of Technology*) is a process model that describes, step by step, the chain of technical actions running from the acquisition of raw materials to the final product. Leroi-Gourhan (1964-65) presented it in pioneering form, and Lemonnier (1986, 1992) refined the concept theoretically. Each operational stage contains technical choices, and technology is embedded in social and cultural context (Lemonnier 1992).

The sequence "selection of materials → chain of processing operations → formation of the product → transmission of technique" in chaine operatoire corresponds naturally to "Wave → Edge → Vortex → Bundle" in the five-stage model. The fact that each stage of processing involves judgment and adjustment in accordance with the state of the material is a material realization of the indeterminacy that characterizes relations within Edge. The production process also clearly begins from Field, understood as unprocessed material, thereby compensating for the weaker correspondence with Field in sections 5.1 through 5.6.

This theory belongs to the context of the anthropology of technology and archaeology. Leroi-Gourhan (1964-65) was the pioneer, and Lemonnier (1986, 1992) developed the theory. In archaeology, it became the standard framework for debitage, the analysis of lithic production flakes. It connects with the attention to things found in the theory of the gift, yet differs in that gift theory treats the movement and circulation of things, whereas chaine operatoire treats their production and transformation. It also has a strong point of contact with traditional knowledge and techniques.

5.8 Symbolic Boundaries and Social Boundaries: A Two-Layer Model of Boundaries

In Lamont, M. & Molnar, V. (2002 "The Study of Boundaries in the Social Sciences." *Annual Review of Sociology* 28: 167-195), "symbolic boundaries and social boundaries" distinguishes sym-

bolic boundaries as "intersubjectively agreed-upon cognitive distinctions" from social boundaries as "institutionalized social differences," that is, objectified divisions involving unequal access to resources and opportunities (Lamont & Molnar 2002). Symbolic boundaries are a necessary condition for social boundaries, but not a sufficient one. When symbolic boundaries become widely shared and institutionally supported, they are converted into social boundaries.

The process "symbolic boundary → institutionalization as social boundary" corresponds structurally to the transition "Edge → Vortex → Bundle" in the five-stage model. The conversion of symbolic boundaries, understood as cognitive distinctions, into social boundaries, understood as institutional divisions, is precisely the process through which relations generated in Edge arise as Vortex and become institutionalized as Bundle. The conditional nature of the conversion, necessary but not sufficient, resonates with the possibility that Edge does not always lead to Vortex, as also seen in schism.

This is a review article spanning sociology and anthropology. Lamont & Molnar (2002) extend and organize Barth's (1969) concept of ethnic boundary across the social sciences more broadly. Published in the *Annual Review of Sociology*, it has become a standard reference in boundary studies. It requires overlap management with sociology, but in the present entry it is positioned as an application of boundary concepts in anthropological context.

5.9 Contact Zone: The Boundary as a Space of Contact

In Pratt, M. L. (1991 "Arts of the Contact Zone." *Profession* 91, MLA), the "contact zone" is defined as a "social space where cultures meet, clash, and grapple with each other," often in contexts of asymmetrical power such as colonialism (Pratt 1991). Linguistic and representational practices within the contact zone, such as writing, speaking, and translating, produce new relations and new forms of self-description while remaining bound up with negotiations of power.

The contact zone is a spatial realization of Edge. A "social space where cultures meet, clash, and grapple" corresponds directly to the definition of Edge as a boundary region in which interaction among multiple elements takes place. The spatiality of the zone resonates with the band-like quality of margin in rites of passage and reinforces the point that Edge is not a line but a band.

This concept belongs to the context of literary studies and cultural anthropology. Pratt (1991) has strong connections to postcolonial theory. It has been taken up in education and cultural studies as well, sometimes in ways that weaken its original emphasis on asymmetrical power. Although it developed independently of Turner's concept of liminality, it connects to it through the shared theme of generation within boundary space.

5.10 Structuration Theory/Practical Sense: The Circulation of Reproduction and Transformation

In Giddens, A. (1984 *The Constitution of Society*); Bourdieu, P. (1980 *Le sens pratique*), "structuration theory/practical sense" concerns the circulation through which reproduction and transformation occur. Giddens's duality of structure holds that structure is at once the medium of action and the outcome of action. Structure is reproduced through the practices of agents (Giddens 1984). Bourdieu's habitus is a system of embodied dispositions in which social structure has been incorporated. Practice in the field/champ reproduces structure while also being capable of transforming it through improvisatory responses to situations (Bourdieu 1980).

The circuit in which repeated practice reproduces structure while also transforming it is structurally similar to the circulation of the five-stage model, Bundle → Field → Wave → .... The fact that habitus, as embodied structure, functions as the Field of subsequent practice amounts to a theorization of the Bundle → Field circulation. The duality of structure, structure as both

medium and outcome of action, offers a social-theoretical description of the circulation in which Bundle becomes the next Field.

This discussion belongs to the shared terrain of sociology and anthropology. Giddens (1984) belongs to sociology, while Bourdieu (1980) is deeply tied to anthropological fieldwork, with *Le sens pratique* grounded in research on Kabyle society. Both share the problem of overcoming the dualism of objectivism and subjectivism, though their approaches differ: Giddens pursues abstract theoretical construction, whereas Bourdieu remains rooted in ethnographic inquiry. Overlap management with sociology is necessary here as well.

6. Cross-Cutting Patterns

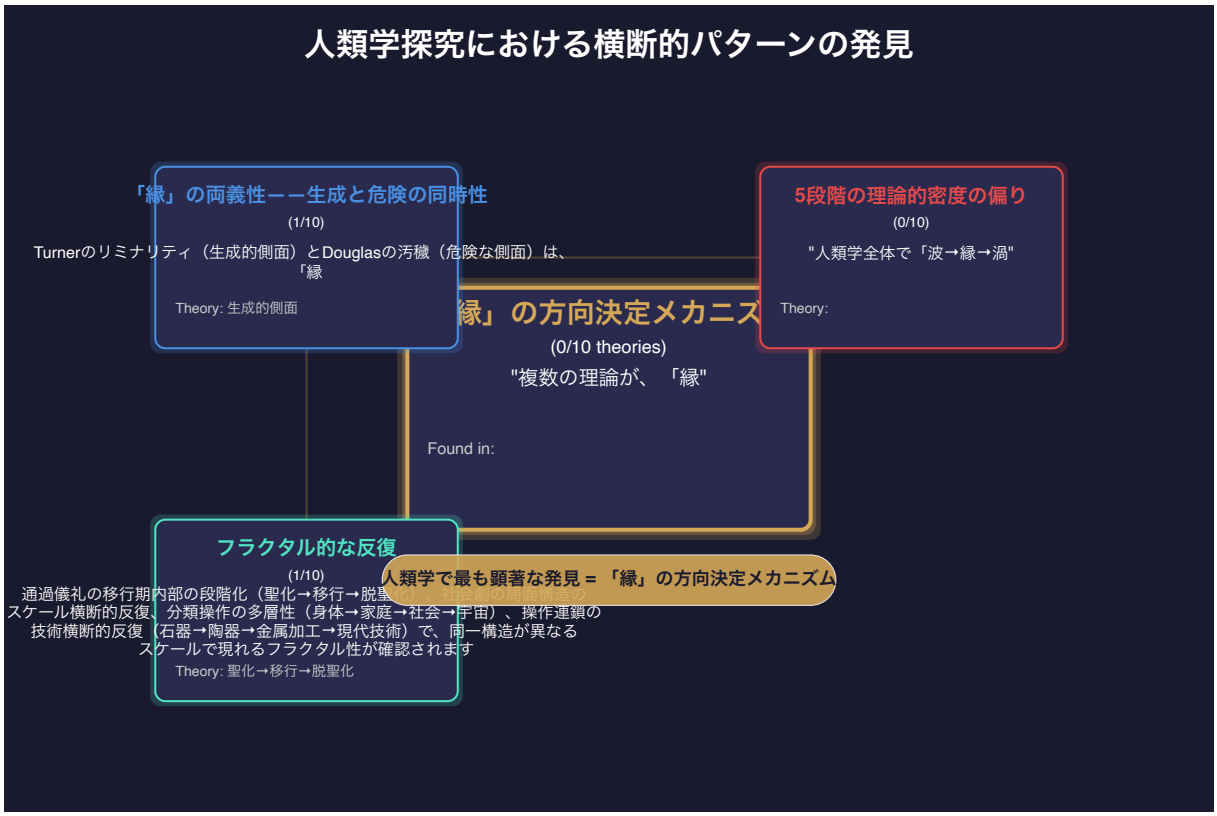

Figure 3: Boundary Processes and the Five-Stage Model in Anthropology and Ethnology —

First, as shown by the three phases of rites of passage, social drama, and liminality and communitas, this domain describes difference and conflict not merely as obstacles but as conditions under which new order comes into being. This means that, within the five stages, the transition from Edge to Vortex is especially richly observable in this domain.

Second, what purity and taboo, ethnic boundaries, and the theory of the gift share is that generation is not a one-off event but includes a circulation of prior-condition formation, amplification of tension, local ordering, stabilization, and subsequent reconfiguration. This confirms that the five-stage model must be read not as a static classificatory chart but as a temporal movement.

By contrast, contact zone, the boundary as a space of contact, also shows that correspondence with the five-stage model does not arise automatically. Similarity in the number of stages or nearness in vocabulary is not enough. It is necessary to examine, in each case, which concept bears the turning point and at what level the structure emerges.

7. Unresolved Questions

1. To what extent can contact zone, the boundary as a space of contact, be read as a stage description within the five-stage model?
2. To what extent can the structures confirmed in this domain be extended from the explanation of particular cases into a more general model of generation? The conditions under which comparability can be maintained without losing the specificity of the object still require further scrutiny.
3. Should the five stages be read as a linear progression, or rather as a circulation that includes multiple temporal layers and repetition? There are significant differences among the theories, especially in the extent to which they explicitly indicate the return from Bundle to the next Field.
4. What becomes visible, and what is lost, when the vocabulary specific to this domain is translated into the general vocabulary of the five stages? The boundary between translatability and untranslatability is itself an important issue for future comparative inquiry.

8. Conclusion

This reconsideration of the domain confirmed strong structural correspondence in 9 of the 10 theories examined and conditional correspondence in 1. In particular, the three phases of rites of passage, social drama, and liminality and communitas provide thick descriptions of the transition from Field to Edge, or from Edge to Vortex, within the five-stage model and should be regarded as central evidence in this domain.

At the same time, the findings in this domain do not support the claim that the same five stages appear in identical form in every theory. The stages that stand out most strongly differ from theory to theory, and some cases require reservations in stage mapping. What matters, therefore, is not generalizing directly from the high rate of correspondence, but continuing to compare which moments are described with which vocabulary.

In that sense, this domain not only supports the validity of the five-stage model in one direction but also imposes conditions on how the model should be read. The very fact that the corpus contains both theories that correspond thickly and theories that require reservation constitutes part of its value as a comparative investigation.